CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SOCIAL WORKER IN THE AI ERA

Systems are cold. The social worker is the warm human who walks a family through them.

★ **TL;DR — Social work at a ~$62K median, growing +6% with ~69,100 openings a year. The honest beginner figure is lower — BSW-level pay starts around $48K — because the median is pulled up by the licensed clinical tier. The catch: heavy caseloads, and clinical work is legally closed until the master's ladder is climbed.** ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

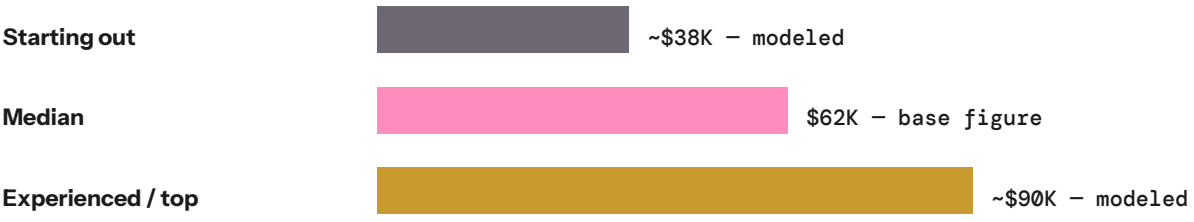
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$62K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Correction to our old card: $45K was roughly the beginner's wage, not the median. The occupation medians $61,780; hospitals median $77,440, individual and family services $51,980.
- The ladder is the product: BSW for nonclinical entry, then MSW, supervised clinical hours and the clinical exam to the LCSW — where the $67,880 healthcare median and the six-figure top decile live.
- AI is absorbing paperwork, not casework: about two-thirds of social workers report using it, mostly for correspondence, reports and documentation (NASW survey, 2025).

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Social Worker is a ~$62K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer

and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SOCIAL WORKER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Assessing clients' situations, risks and needs
- ✓ Connecting families to housing, benefits and services
- ✓ Home visits, case documentation and follow-ups
- ✓ Coordinating with courts, schools, hospitals and agencies

Think: a navigator for people in the worst month of their lives.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Documentation, correspondence and report drafting; intake screening scores used as decision support by human staff. The automatable slice is the paperwork beginners hate most.	Home visits, crisis response, mandated reporting, court-facing casework — and all clinical judgement, which states license and are actively walling off from AI substitution.

⚠ **THE CASELOAD MATH: standards say 12–15 children per caseworker; reported actuals run roughly double that. Burnout is the occupational hazard, and the BSW tier is structurally a way-station — stop there and the pay stops too, around the $51,980 family-services median.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Work measured in families stabilised, not tickets closed ✓ A licence ladder that keeps paying as you climb ✓ AI eating the notes, not the visits	✗ Caseloads above the standard, as a rule ✗ Other people's worst months, daily ✗ Pay that lags the emotional weight for years

Good fit? Steady under other people's chaos, deeply organized, and motivated by people over money.
Bad fit? You need emotional distance from work, or a fast route to a high salary.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — THE BACHELOR'S ROUTE (BSW)	DOOR B — THE MASTER'S ROUTE (MSW)

An accredited BSW, with supervised fieldwork, hires you into nonclinical work: child and family casework, benefits and resources, agency roles. Expect around $48,410 at the bachelor's level (ASWB workforce survey) — a start, not the median. First move: field placements in the setting you want to work in; agencies hire their own interns first, and half of bachelor's-level workers are already planning the master's — plan yours from the start.	Straight to the MSW (about 2 years; BSW holders can finish faster) if clinical work is the goal — diagnosis and therapy are legally closed without it. After the degree comes supervised clinical practice over several years, then the clinical exam and the LCSW. That's where the healthcare ($67,880) and hospital ($77,440) medians live. First move: choose the MSW by its clinical placement network, not its brochure.

Smart move: Do your field placements in the setting you want to be hired into. Agencies hire their own interns first, and your supervisor becomes your reference.
Where you land after: Senior caseworker, licensed clinical practice, or program management in agencies and hospitals.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP THE	ENTER AN	FIELD PLACEMENTS	COMPLETE THE	LICENSE EXAM	TAKE YOUR

STEP 1 — Map the license ladder

FREE · TODAY

- Five ASWB licence levels exist: bachelor's is the entry rung, clinical is the top — pin your target job to the right rung
- Decide now: nonclinical entry on the BSW, or clinical work as the destination via the MSW ladder

STEP 2 — Enter an accredited program

TUITION · YEAR 1

- BSW for the working start; MSW direct if you can fund it
- Accreditation is non-negotiable — unaccredited degrees don't lead to licences

STEP 3 — Field placements

YEARS 1-2

- Placements in your target setting: hospital, school, child welfare, agency
- Your supervisor becomes your reference; treat the placement as a long interview

STEP 4 — Complete the degree

YEARS 2-3

- Graduate with documented casework, not just coursework
- BSW route: file for your state's bachelor's-level licence or credential where offered

STEP 5 — License exam and application

LICENSE · FINAL YEAR

- Pass the ASWB exam at your level; clear the background requirements
- Clinical track: register your supervised-hours plan with the state board

STEP 6 — Take your first caseload

FINAL MONTHS

- Apply into the settings with the openings — healthcare and mental-health roles grow fastest (+8–10%)
- Negotiate supervision quality and caseload size; both decide whether you last

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: your state's licence levels written out, with the job you want pinned to the right rung.
- □ Days 1–30: accredited program chosen; placement settings shortlisted.
- □ Days 31–60: coursework started; first placement conversations held.
- □ Days 61–90: field placement secured or scheduled; exam timeline on the calendar.
- □ Day 90: you're climbing a ladder with named rungs — not hoping a vague 'helping' job appears.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ BE THE PERSON WHO KNOWS THE WAY. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.